

file is “clean”. Modern anti-virus software employs various techniques to counter stealth mechanisms of viruses.

Other malware such as worms and Trojans have also been instrumental for a number of Internet outages in the past. Unlike viruses and worms, Trojans cannot replicate and spread on their own.

The term ‘Trojan’ is derived from the classical myth of the Trojan horse. Towards the end of the siege of Troy, the Greeks left a large wooden horse outside the city. The Trojans, convinced that it was a gift, moved the horse to a place within the city walls. As it turned out the horse was hollow and had Greek soldiers hiding inside it. These soldiers then opened the city gates of Troy at night, making it possible for the Greek army to pillage the city. A Trojan is a malicious program that is disguised as legitimate software. The useful, or seemingly useful, functions serve as camouflage for the undesired operations that the software performs.

Recently written Trojans also contain functions and strategies that enable them to spread. This moves them closer to the definition of computer viruses, and it becomes difficult to clearly distinguish such mixed programs between Trojan horses and viruses.

A number of anti-virus software are available in the market today, each employing multiple methods to detect, and if possible, eliminate the program. In the next chapter on ‘Tools and Utilities’, we shall take a brief look at the various anti-virus software available, and understand their generic functions.